Raghunandana Thakura

Рагхунандана Тхакур · @raghunandana

The Son Whom His Father Called Father

Raghunandana Thakura of Shrikhanda was the son of Mukunda Dasa and the nephew of Narahari Sarakara Thakura — a companion in the pastimes of Sri Sri Gaura-Krishna, a maha-bhagavata full of love for Krishna, like his father. All the biographies call him by this name; in one place he is called Raghunandana Dasa, and Lochana Dasa recalls that Abhirama Gosvami proclaimed Madana in him.

Krishnadasa Kaviraja, listing the branches of Sri Chaitanya's tree, names the residents of Shrikhanda as a great branch, an abode of His mercy:

“Mukunda Dasa of Shrikhanda and his son Raghunandana, as well as Narahari, Chiranjiva and Sulochana, are branches of Sri Chaitanya's tree of bhakti, who everywhere and in every place generously distributed the fruits and flowers of divine love for Krishna.” (CC, Adi 10.78–79)

Of all the residents of Khanda who were Gaura's companions, three were foremost:

“In the village of Khanda there lived at that time three eminent devotees: Mukunda Dasa, Sri Raghunandana and Sri Narahari.” (CC, Madhya 15.112)

Raghunandana's greatness is best shown by one conversation in Puri. The Lord lovingly asked Mukunda which of them was the father and which the son — and heard an answer that delighted Him:

“The son of mother Shachi asked Mukunda Dasa: ‘Tell Me, Mukunda. Is Sri Raghunandana your son and you his father? Or is Raghunandana your father and you his son? Answer definitely and dispel My doubt.’ Mukunda replied: ‘I consider Raghunandana my father and myself his son. All of us obtained devotion to Krishna by Raghunandana's grace, and therefore he is my father. Of this I am convinced.’ Sri Chaitanya joyfully exclaimed: ‘So it is indeed! The guru is the one from whom Krishna-bhakti comes.’” (CC, Madhya 15.113–117)

It is not age that makes one an elder, a guru: whoever brings bhakti to others is the father, and a person's measure is the depth of his devotion. With these words the Lord revealed who Raghunandana is.

A Family of Vaidyas

Raghunandana was born in Shrikhanda, into a family of vaidyas — hereditary physicians — in the year 1432 of the Shaka era (1510), on the day of Vasanta-panchami.[1] Our calendar observes the Appearance Day of Srila Raghunandana Thakura in the month of Madhava, on Gaura-panchami — the fifth lunar day of the bright fortnight, Sri Krishna Vasanta-panchami. His mother's name is unknown. Mukunda Dasa's house stands about a mile from Shrikhanda station; the village itself lies four miles west of Katwa.

Raghunandana's paternal grandfather was Narayana Dasa, also called Narayanadeva Sarakara. He had three sons: the eldest Mukunda, the middle Madhava and the youngest Narahari.[2] For more on the family see the article on Narahari Sarakara.

Outwardly Mukunda was a Vaishnava householder and a court physician — people saw in him a doctor at the court of Husain Shah — but inwardly he was a maha-bhagavata, a paramahamsa, whose heart overflowed with love for Krishna:

“Outwardly he is a royal physician in government service. But who is able to understand how vast his love for God is?” (CC, Madhya 15.120)

The Lord Himself used to tell His devotees how once a fan of peacock feathers was raised over the padishah's head and Mukunda, remembering Krishna, fell senseless. The padishah himself came down to him; Mukunda blamed it on epilepsy, but the ruler understood that a great saint stood before him and sent him home with honour (CC, Madhya 15.121–127).

His uncle took great care over the boy's upbringing: Narahari loved him dearly, and Raghunandana became his disciple. An old Sanskrit verse glorifies Mukunda Dasa for having as his son Raghunandana, beautiful as Kandarpa, who fed Gopala laddus: he is worthy of honour, Narahari's disciple, righteous and esteemed by the good, pure in conduct from childhood, his heart washed clean by bhakti.

Laddus for Gopinatha

Love for Krishna awakened in him from the age of five, says the “Guna-charita-mahima-lesha.” Its verse glorifies Raghunandana, who dwells in the land of Shrikhanda: from his fifth year, sweet with the rapture of Krishna's rasa, he manifested the beautiful Deity of Sri Gopinatha and circumambulated Him in service, and in his childhood play Gopinatha joyfully ate sweet rice.[3]

The household Deity of Mukunda's family was Gopinatha — Krishna.[4] The song-poet Uddhava Dasa tells in a song what happened next. Once Mukunda, leaving on business — according to one biography, to treat a patient — told his son to feed the Deity with care. The boy set the food before Him and, weeping, began to plead, “Eat!” — and Krishna, obedient to love, unseen ate everything to the last crumb. On his return Mukunda asked for prasada, and the son innocently replied that He had eaten it all.

Another time Mukunda gave the same instruction, but on returning he hid and watched. Raghunandana placed a laddu in Gopinatha's hand and kept saying, “Eat, eat!” The Deity ate half — and the moment Mukunda appeared in the doorway, stopped eating. One biography explains that the first time He had already eaten His fill, and so ate only half. Mukunda, overwhelmed with love, took his son on his lap and embraced him, speaking in a choked voice and shedding streams of tears. Uddhava Dasa ends his song with the words: he who is non-different from Madana is Sri Raghunandana himself.

Half of that laddu is still in the Deity's hand at Shrikhanda: it is kept in one of the village temples, and the fortunate come there to see it. The “Bhakti-ratnakara” tells that all the mahantas gathered at Shrikhanda were enchanted on seeing the Gopinatha whom Raghunandana had fed. So Krishna submits to love: the boy's childlike simplicity and tears made the Deity eat.

Lochana Dasa recalls this in the “Chaitanya-mangala”:

“He who fed the Sri Murti a sweet ball (laddu) — what fool would think him of little understanding? <…> He whose constant vow is converse with the Sri Murti — how can you know what he is, what his greatness is?” (“Chaitanya-mangala,” Sutra-khanda 648, 650)

Service to Krishna

All his life Raghunandana served Krishna in his house-temple. The Lord Himself describes the place:

“Raghunandana serves in Krishna's temple, and in front of that temple there is a wonderful lake. On the bank of that lake a kadamba tree blossoms all year round, and every day two new flowers open on it for Krishna's service.” (CC, Madhya 15.128–129)[5]

Bidding farewell to the devotees of Gauda, Mahaprabhu gave each of the residents of Shrikhanda his own service. He told Raghunandana to serve the Deity, thinking of nothing else:

“Raghunandana, for his part, should continue his service to Krishna, for without it he cannot even conceive of his life.” (CC, Madhya 15.131)

According to one biography, Mahaprabhu, the father of sankirtana, gave Raghunandana, as though to an adopted son, the right to offer the garland at the adhivasa on the eve of the sankirtana-yajna and to make the concluding offering at its end. Lochana Dasa writes that Chaitanya told him, “You are My life,” and more than once paints Gaurasundara with Gadadhara on His left, Narahari on His right and Raghunandana at His feet, all with their companions drinking the nectar of His moonlike face.

A Deity of Sri Gauranga was installed in Raghunandana's temple. According to the “Bhakti-ratnakara,” in Gauranga's courtyard he and the devotees would watch the morning and evening arati and sing and dance in kirtana; in the eighth wave of the same book, as one biography cites it, it is said that he served the Deity of Lord Chaitanya.[6]

Every Year to Puri

When the Lord returned from the South, the residents of Khanda set out to Him together with everyone:

“Mukunda, Narahari and Raghunandana of Khanda also came to the Acharya's house in order to go with Him to Jagannatha Puri.” (CC, Madhya 10.90)

From then on, as long as the Lord was manifest, Raghunandana went to Nilachala every year with the Bengali devotees for the chaturmasya. Mukunda, Narahari, Raghunandana and Chiranjiva lived in Khanda, one in purpose, and every year went together to Puri for the Ratha-yatra. When King Prataparudra watched the arrivals from Gauda, Gopinatha Acharya pointed out Raghunandana to him as well:

“And here are the residents of Khanda: Mukunda Dasa, Narahari, Sri Raghunandana, Chiranjiva and Sulochana.” (CC, Madhya 11.92)

At the Lord's wish he danced and sang before Jagannatha's chariot. Of the seven kirtana parties one was from Shrikhanda:

“The singers of Khanda formed the seventh party. Its dancers were Narahari and Raghunandana.” (CC, Madhya 13.46)

Kavi Karnapura speaks of them in the “Chaitanya-chandrodaya-nataka”:

“Some natives of Khanda, headed by Narahari and Raghunandana — though from ‘Khanda,’ ‘a fragment,’ yet of unbroken (‘akhanda’) good fortune — who had not seen him before, attain Purushottama every autumn.” (“Chaitanya-chandrodaya,” 9.1)

And Murari Gupta in his “Kadacha” sees them in the kirtana at Nilachala:

“…and Sri Raghunandana and the others who live at Khanda, and the dwellers of Kulinagrama — all whose hearts are imbued with feeling for Gauranga — joyfully dance and sing and bow down without cease.” (Murari Gupta, “Kadacha” 4.1.5)

In one song ascribed to Vrindavana Dasa, among those dancing in Mahaprabhu's kirtana are named the handsome Ramai and Sri Raghunandana, Srivasa, Haridasa, Vakreshvara, Dvija Haridasa and Shankara; whether this is the same Raghunandana the song does not make clear.

As the Vaishnavas Saw Him

Lochana Dasa, his uncle's disciple, devotes a whole hymn of praise to him at the end of the Sutra-khanda:

“His nephew, Sri Raghunandana Thakura, is widely proclaimed throughout the world. <…> A Vaishnava by nature is beyond the bounds of varna; he who converses with Krishna has Krishna alone. <…> He to whom Chaitanya said, ‘You are My life,’ whom Abhirama Gosvami revealed, making

known that he was the avatara of Madana — and all saw him so on Chaitanya's lap.[7] When he dances absorbed in Krishna he enchants the world's heart; he has no ‘mine’ and ‘another's’ — the same love for all. Always sweet words come from his lips; no one ever heard a harsh word from him. Skill, sweetness, lila, play, loveliness — his body, full of rasa, is blessed in this world. His father is the wise Sri Mukunda Dasa, pure in faith on the path approved by Chaitanya.” (“Chaitanya-mangala,” Sutra-khanda 647–656)

The old song-poets sing of him in the same way: “I praise the sweet nature of Sri Raghunandana, whose form and character enchant the world”; “I praise Raghunandana: his form is like Madana's, and his dance enchants the world.” His captivating form is described in all the ancient padas.

When the festival of separation from Narahari was held at Shrikhanda, the assembled mahantas, according to the “Bhakti-ratnakara,” said of Raghunandana: whoever loves him has Sri Krishna Chaitanya under his control birth after birth; he is so merciful that he has become the life of the most fallen, the poor and the suffering; so humble that no one is meeker than he; he shines like Kandarpa; and, as someone added, he is wonderfully steadfast in song, music and dance.

Shrikhanda had once been a stronghold of Shakta-tantric worship. By the power of Mukunda, Narahari and Raghunandana it became, from the sixteenth century, a prominent centre of Gaudiya Vaishnava preaching, and historians note the distinctive character of that preaching. But the doctrines of “gaura-nagari” and “gaura-vadi” were not held by the three chief companions of Shrikhanda: wilful people invented them later and tried to tie them to their names.[8] These inventions have nothing to do with the pure companions of Shrikhanda.

Abhirama and the Ankle Bell

It is said that only one who sincerely loves Krishna could withstand the obeisance of Abhirama Thakura and the stroke of his whip Jayamangala. In another song Uddhava Dasa tells how Abhirama came to Shrikhanda looking for Raghunandana. Mukunda, fearing that he would bow down to his son, hid him, but Raghunandana himself went to a place called Baradangi (Badadangi), met Abhirama there and withstood his mighty obeisance; then together they sang the names of Gaura and Nityananda and danced in love of God — according to one biography, in the house of a certain devotee.[9]

In this dance the nupura — an ankle bell — flew from Raghunandana's foot and fell four miles away, at Akai-hat, by the house of Krishnadasa, whom one biography calls his disciple; later a pond was dug there in memory of this — Nupura-kunda (according to another biography, the ankle bell fell straight into a pond, which has borne that name ever since). Nupura-kunda is still shown near the shripata of Lavanga-sakhi, Kala Krishnadasa, at Akai-hat.[10] The ankle bell itself, it is said, together with the Deities of the Akai-hat shripata — Sri Radhavallabha and Sri Gopala — is kept to this day in the house of the mahantas in the village of Kadui, three kroshas from Akai-hat.[11]

Srinivasa and Narottama

The residents of Shrikhanda loved Srinivasa Acharya from his very birth: at the infant's childhood rites he was blessed by Govinda Ghosha, Narahari and Raghunandana. Narahari, Raghunandana and all the residents of Shrikhanda loved him with parental love — vatsalya — and Raghunandana was especially attached to him. When Srinivasa came to Shrikhanda and told them that he wished to go to Puri, they rejoiced and told him to wait a few days so as to go with the Bengali devotees. Karnapura Kaviraja, Srinivasa's disciple, recalls in a verse how, setting out, Srinivasa bowed in Khanda to Sarakara Thakura, received his command, then bowed at Raghunandana's feet and went on, remembering them.

The news of the Lord's concealment reached Srinivasa on the road. Returning to Bengal, he first of all came to Shrikhanda to Narahari and Raghunandana, and on his way back from Khanakula visited them

again; they were among the Lord's companions who told him to go to Vrindavana. Later, having received Ishana's blessing and embrace in Navadvipa, Srinivasa, Narottama and Ramachandra Kaviraja set out for Shrikhanda to Raghunandana and learned on the way that Ishana had departed. Ramachandra left for Vrindavana with the permission and blessing of Raghunandana and other Vaishnavas.

When news came of Vishnupriya's passing, Raghunandana sent Srinivasa an invitation to Yajigrama, and he came to Shrikhanda at once. Then Raghunandana himself came to Yajigrama and arranged Srinivasa's marriage to Draupadi, daughter of Gopala Chakravarti of Yajigrama, who at initiation received the name Ishvari; the wedding took place on the krishna-tritiya of the month of Vaishakha.[12] On Narahari's conversation with Srinivasa before the wedding see the article on Narahari Sarakara.

Narottama Dasa, on his way back from Orissa, came to Shrikhanda and bowed to Narahari and Raghunandana; Raghunandana embraced him lovingly, and they asked him about the devotees of Puri. Narottama visited the shripatas of Narahari and Raghunandana.

When Narahari left this world, Raghunandana was plunged in grief and, on seeing Srinivasa, was somewhat consoled. It was he who instituted the festival of separation from Narahari at Shrikhanda, and he held it together with Srinivasa and others; it was then that the assembled mahantas glorified his greatness. He was also at the festival of separation from Gadadhara Dasa in Katwa.

Kheturi

To the great festival that Narottama arranged at Kheturi Raghunandana came from Shrikhanda with many devotees; among the guests were Jahnava Devi and many other companions of the Lord. On the evening before the Appearance Day of Mahaprabhu he began the preliminary kirtana, and the singing went on until midnight. At the request of Narottama and Srinivasa he sang the mangalacharana — the opening, auspicious kirtana — and when Sri Gauranga Himself appeared with His associates among the devotees in the great kirtana, Raghunandana danced with everyone (“Bhakti-ratnakara” 10.572).

Shyamananda, returning from Kheturi, stayed at Shrikhanda in Raghunandana's house, and Jahnava Devi, on her way back from Vrindavana, also visited his home. And when Virachandra, Nityananda's son, travelling through Bengal, came to Shrikhanda, he was lovingly received, according to the “Bhakti-ratnakara,” by Raghunandana's son Kanai Thakura — this is told after Raghunandana's departure.[13]

Departure

Before his departure Raghunandana sent a devotee to Yajigrama to call Srinivasa. He soon came to Shrikhanda and bowed down, and Raghunandana blessed him: “Live long and preach the message of Sri Gauranga everywhere.” According to the “Bhakti-ratnakara,” he told Srinivasa that hard times were coming and that false reasoning and doubts would enter people's hearts — as Narahari Prabhu had written in the “Sri-Krishna-bhajanamrita” (3–4). But there was no need to worry: through Srinivasa Gauranga would do great things; let him and his followers guard the Lord's teaching, and the opponents of bhakti would by his power become devotees and take shelter of him. Through Srinivasa's preaching of pure bhakti, those who seek the true good would cross this ocean of doubt.

Then he went to the Deity, called his son Kanai and handed the service over to him, and surrendered himself at the feet of his Deities. For three days the devotees sang sankirtana; then he once more surrendered himself to Narahari's Deities, Sri Gauranga and Sri Madana-Gopala, and under their merciful gaze left this world. The “Bhakti-ratnakara” says that he gradually vanished from sight, repeating again and again the names of Sri Krishna Chaitanya, and glorifies that day — the chaturthi of the bright fortnight of the month of Shravana:[14] who would not sing the glory of Raghunandana! The

biographies do not give the year of his departure; he departed at Shrikhanda.

After his departure his son Kanai Thakura, together with Srinivasa, held a festival of separation at Shrikhanda, inviting all of Mahaprabhu's devotees. According to one biography, in the great kirtana in the courtyard Raghunandana himself appeared, dancing, and whoever saw that festival or even heard of it attained the goal of life. Srinivasa returned to Yajigrama with a heavy heart and from there went to Vana-Vishnupura, where he married a second time.

Descendants and Disciples

Raghunandana's son was Kanai Thakura; at Narahari's command, it is said, he manifested at Shrikhanda the service of Gauranga and Vishnupriya. Kanai had two sons — Madana Raya, a disciple of Narahari Sarakara, and Vamshi Raya, or Vamshivadana.

Madana Raya had a son Bhagavan and four other sons. From Bhagavan the line ran thus: Ratikanta, Pranavallabha, Jayakrishna, Kandarpa, Achyutananda, Nrisimhananda. Nrisimhananda's sons were Vrajananda and Lalitananda. From Vrajananda came Gopikananda, from him Yugalananda, from him Gauragunananda. Lalitananda's sons were Premananda and Keshavananda; Premananda's sons were Sarvananda (whose son was Jivananda), Kishorananda and Dvarakinatha; Keshavananda's sons were Kirtanananda, Rakhalananda and Banavarinanda.

Raghunandana's descendants still live at Shrikhanda; one of the best known is Panchanana Kaviraja. According to Bhaktivedanta Swami, drawing on Bhaktivinoda Thakura's commentary, the family numbers no fewer than four hundred men, and all their names are recorded at Shrikhanda.

The poet Rayashekhara, or Kavishekhara Raya, is known as a “disciple” of Raghunandana; many padas in Brajabuli circulate under this name. In general, quite a few padas on Gauranga bear the names of his disciples and their disciples, but they cannot all be accepted indiscriminately — not everything ascribed to them is genuine. Some consider the Sanskrit hymns “Sri Gaura-namamrita-stotra” and “Sri Shachisutashtaka” to be the works of Raghunandana himself.

Pradyumna

Kavi Karnapura in the “Gaura-ganoddesha-dipika” reveals who he is in the eternal pastimes:

“The third vyuha, Pradyumna, became the dear confidential friend (priya-narma-sakha) who assisted in the pastimes of Radha and Madhava in Vraja; non-different in body from Sri Chaitanya, he is Raghunandana.” (GGD 70)

One biography specifies that he is Sri Pradyumna-Vishnu of the Vraja-lila. Pradyumna, Krishna's son in Dvaraka, is the one called Kandarpa and Madana; that is why Abhirama proclaimed Madana in him, why Uddhava's song calls him non-different from Madana, and why the poets compare his beauty with Kandarpa's.[15]

So Raghunandana, who fed Gopinatha laddus, is the one who in Vraja assists the pastimes of Radha and Madhava, and who in Gaura-lila bestows bhakti even on his own father.